

Afternoon Discoveries

September 27, 2026



AMONG THE LETTERS

SEP 27, 2026



Emerging Writers, Debuts, & Reading Worth Revisiting

Sunday is where new voices meet work that deserves another look.

Today begins with writers still building their first bodies of work, moves through forthcoming debuts, recent fiction and poetry, and then reaches backward toward three stories that have stayed in circulation for very good reasons.

Some of these writers are arriving with first books. Others are still appearing story by story. Either way, there is something rewarding about finding a voice while the path ahead of it is still being made.

All links were checked against the linked magazine, publisher, or author page on September 27, 2026.

Featured Discovery

The Big Reboot - Michael Hughes Wesner

After surviving decapitation, Ian wakes in a hospital with a prosthetic head, an incomplete memory, and a family trying to help him adjust to whatever counts as the same person now.

Michael Hughes Wesner lets the absurdity of that premise carry a breezy comic voice, but the story keeps returning to more difficult questions about self-perception, physical appearance, trauma, and the distance between being alive and feeling restored. Guest judge Jim Shepard selected it for third place in The Masters Review's Winter Short Story Award for New Writers, and Wesner is currently an MFA candidate whose short fiction is still early in its publication life.

[Read The Big Reboot at The Masters Review](#)

The Discovery Desk

Parts Work **- Sarah Edwards**

Sarah Edwards builds this story almost entirely from questions.

They begin playfully with alternate lives, bad decisions, impossible accidents, and imagined romances. Then, gradually the questions circle closer to experiences the narrator has learned to minimize, explain away, or reconsider through therapy. The repeated “What if?” becomes less a game of possibility than a way of asking how differently a life might feel if certain moments had gone another way.

[Read Parts Work at Necessary Fiction](#)

What I Learned About Dogs in the Village **- Ajla Dizdarevic**

Debutiful is offering three early poems from Ajla Dizdarevic’s first collection, due from Carnegie Mellon University Press in 2027.

The poems approach the long aftermath of the Bosnian War through family history, inheritance, displacement, bureaucracy, language, and dark humour. One moves through the poet’s surname and cultural inheritance, another toward her father’s childhood and survival, while the third assembles a life from fragments of voice and memory. Together they make an unusually substantial introduction to a debut still several months away.

[Read the three poems at Debutiful](#)

Love and Medicine - Virginia Marshall

Julia comes from a family of doctors, but when she becomes a patient herself, medical authority begins to look different from the other side of the exam room.

Virginia Marshall follows desire, illness, family expectation, and the uneasy intimacy that can develop when someone is both frightened of a body and dependent on another person to interpret it. Marshall was a 2023-2024 Susan Kamil Emerging Writer Fellow at the Center for Fiction, and the story offers a strong introduction to a writer currently working on her first novel.

[Read Love and Medicine at The Rumpus](#)

Rendered - Glen Creed

A mother cuts fat from her own body, renders it down, and uses it to light two small wax figures.

Then they begin to move.

Glen Creed needs very little space to establish the rules of this grief-stricken ritual. The physical details are unsettling, but the heart of the story lies in the impossible bargain beneath them: how much of yourself would you give to recreate someone you have lost, especially when the recreation is almost, but never entirely, right?

[Read or listen to Rendered at SmokeLong Quarterly](#)

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Drawers of the Discovery Desk

Retention - Ashley Mangtani

A hospital retention pond becomes connected to another body of water, the reservoir that swallowed the narrator's grandmother's town after the Army Corps of Engineers built a dam in 1961.

Ashley Mangtani lets those two landscapes run together through memory, institutional care, disappearance, and the things governments or systems decide can be submerged for a larger purpose. The story's water imagery carries both comfort and unease, making forgetting and preservation feel like two sides of the same act.

[Read Retention at SmokeLong Quarterly](#)

Twinkle - Naomi Blythe Gold

Naomi Blythe Gold's story looks back on beauty as inheritance, currency, performance, and something that eventually changes its terms.

The narrator remembers dancing in Guam, the attention of men, poverty, femininity, and the strange comfort of feeling attractive even when attraction itself was not what she wanted. Aging removes one kind of gaze, but the story does not treat that as disappearance. Instead it makes room for the possibility that there are other ways to be visible.

[Read or listen to Twinkle at SmokeLong Quarterly](#)

Holding On is Forever - Mindy Misener

Three calls to a sister provide the structure for this excerpt from Mindy Misener's forthcoming novel *Good Guys*.

What begins with a young woman stranded at a motel gradually becomes a story about the uneven ways family members ask for help, refuse it, offer it badly, and continue reaching toward one another anyway. The excerpt is compact, but the relationship between the sisters feels larger than what is immediately explained.

[Read Holding On is Forever at The Common](#)

Chupacabra - Rodrigo Urquiola Flores, translated by Shaina Brassard

Childhood fear of the chupacabra runs through this semi-autobiographical story from contemporary Bolivian writer Rodrigo Urquiola Flores, presented by *The Common* in English and the original Spanish.

Set around La Paz in the 1990s, the story moves through loneliness, family memory, the spectacle of football, and a grandmother's recollections of an older social order. What begins with a creature from television and rumour gradually opens into the kinds of fear, power, and history children can sense long before they know how to name them.

[Read Chupacabra at The Common](#)

A Seafarer's Trifle - Shelley Roche-Jacques

Cockroaches bring two neighbours together in Shelley Roche-Jacques's wonderfully odd piece of flash fiction.

The narrator barely knows the woman next door, but the thin walls between their homes have carried enough sound for her to understand that a pregnancy has ended. After an exterminator visit and the death of an insect she had accidentally befriended she decides to make a gift and take it next door. It is a small gesture, awkwardly offered, which is precisely why it works.

[Read A Seafarer's Trifle at The Rumpus](#)

Beyond the First Shelf

Interview with the Winner: Michael Hughes Wesner

After *The Big Reboot*, this conversation offers a useful look at what is happening beneath its comic surface.

Wesner discusses humour as a form of deflection, the narrator's complicated relationship with his altered appearance, and the uncertainty surrounding his own intentions and memories. He also talks about his writing routine and current projects. It is a good companion to the story because the interview clarifies how deliberately its jokes are being used to circle things the narrator would rather not confront.

[Read the interview at The Masters Review](#)

Carrie Lee South on Writing Terror for *In the Woods They Wait*

Carrie Lee South's debut novel begins with a teenager whose younger brother disappears in Arkansas's Devil's Den State Park. Then, fifteen years later another child vanishes in the same woods.

In this conversation, South talks about drawing from her own experience of sibling loss, using the Ozarks as more than scenery, and building suspense across two timelines. She is especially interesting on the difference between writing frightening events and writing the guilt and grief surrounding them.

[Read the conversation at Debutiful](#)

Book Review: ***But for Fortune*** **by Erin Miller Reid**

- Reviewed by Karina Gonzalez-Espinoza

Erin Miller Reid's debut novel moves between a medical student in 2000 and her grandmother's experiences with marriage, mental illness, and psychiatric institutionalization in the 1950s.

Karina Gonzalez-Espinoza's review is valuable because it takes the novel's ambitions seriously without flattening its complications. She considers what changes across generations, what does not, and how differently a person can be understood depending on whether medicine gives her the authority to diagnose or makes her the person being diagnosed.

[Read the review at The Masters Review](#)

Special Recommendations

Some pieces earn their place on the shelf by continuing to make readers argue with them years later.

The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas
- Ursula K. Le Guin

Le Guin gives us a beautiful city and then reveals the condition on which its happiness depends: the suffering of one child.

The story is brief, but its ethical problem has proved remarkably durable. Some citizens accept the bargain while others see the child and leave. First published in 1973, and winner of the 1974 Hugo Award for Best Short Story, *Omelas* still works because it refuses to solve the question it creates.

Visit [Ursula K. Le Guin's official page for The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas](#)

Girl **- Jamaica Kincaid**

A mother gives her daughter instructions.

How to wash clothes, how to cook, how to behave, how to love, how not to become the kind of woman people have already warned her about.

Jamaica Kincaid compresses an extraordinary amount of family, culture, discipline, fear, knowledge, and resistance into a piece that moves with almost no pause. The daughter's voice enters only twice, but those brief interruptions are enough to remind us that instruction is not the same thing as obedience.

[Read Girl at The New Yorker](#)

Bullet in the Brain **- Tobias Wolff**

Anders is a book critic who has spent years becoming irritated by almost everything, including language itself.

Then a bank robbery ends with a bullet passing through his brain, and the story slows into the memory that rises before consciousness disappears. It is not one of the grand events of his life. It is a childhood baseball game and a sentence spoken with imperfect grammar that once delighted him because he had never heard anything quite like it.

For a story about death it remains an unexpectedly tender piece about rediscovering wonder in words.

[Read Bullet in the Brain at The New Yorker](#)

Sunday's shelves are a reminder that a literary life rarely announces exactly when it begins.

Sometimes there is a first book; sometimes there is a story in a magazine, a handful of poems, an interview, or simply the first piece that makes someone remember a writer's name. Sometimes an older story is still sitting there years later, ready for a reader who has not found it yet.

Thank you for spending some of your day among the letters with us.

Take care!

✓ **Subscribed**